

Pope Leo XIV's First Encyclical Calls to 'Disarm' AI and Put Humanity First

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The infographic features a dark blue background with a subtle grid and a faint constellation-like line graphic in the top right. The title is in large white and teal font. Below it, a subtitle in smaller white font describes the document. Three key statistics are highlighted in separate boxes with vertical bars: '1.4 Billion' in orange, '5 Chapters' in yellow, and '135 Years' in blue. The date 'May 26, 2026' is at the bottom left, and the 'ToKnow.ai' logo is at the bottom right.

Pope Leo XIV's First Encyclical Calls to 'Disarm' AI

83-page Vatican document on AI, ethics, and human dignity

- 1.4 Billion**
Catholics addressed worldwide
- 5 Chapters**
Covering AI, work, war, and democracy
- 135 Years**
After Rerum novarum on the Industrial Revolution

May 26, 2026

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Pope Leo XIV [published](#) his first encyclical on May 25: “Magnifica humanitas: On Safeguarding the Human Person in the Time of Artificial Intelligence.” The 83-page, five-chapter document is the Catholic Church’s most authoritative statement on AI, directed to 1.4 billion Catholics worldwide. The Pope signed it on May 15, exactly 135 years after Leo XIII’s Rerum novarum, which confronted worker exploitation during the Industrial Revolution. The parallel

is intentional. “Today we find ourselves facing a transformation of similar magnitude, with perhaps even greater consequences,” the Pope [said](#) at the Vatican’s Synod Hall. The encyclical calls for AI to be “disarmed”: freed from military, economic, and cognitive competition. It argues that technology is never neutral and urges an ethical code built on shared standards of social justice, not rules defined by a handful of companies.

Among the [speakers](#) was Christopher Olah, co-founder of Anthropic, who called for “informed critics who will tell the labs when we are failing” and “moral voices that the incentives cannot bend.” The Pope thanked Olah, a non-believer, saying “What a great sign of hope it is that with our differences we can listen to one another.” A tech company co-founder speaking at a papal encyclical launch is highly unusual, and it signals the Vatican engaging directly with the people building AI, not just critiquing from a distance.

A moral framework from an institution with 1.4 billion members, one that calls for AI to serve humanity rather than concentrate power, adds a voice operating outside the usual market and policy incentives. Most AI governance today runs through corporate policies or government regulation. This encyclical introduces a third force: moral authority backed by centuries of institutional credibility.

Read More: [AI This Week: Erdős Conjecture, Karpathy, Gemini 3.5, OpenAI IPO](#)

Sources:

- [Pope Leo’s ‘Magnifica humanitas’: AI must serve humanity \(Vatican News\)](#)
- [Pope calls for robust regulation of AI \(AP News\)](#)
- [Pope Leo Unveils His Encyclical \(National Catholic Register\)](#)
- [Full Text of Magnifica Humanitas \(Vatican.va\)](#)

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